When the Lines Grow Gray

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Imagine two farms sitting side by side. For generations, a fence has marked the boundary between them. Everyone knows where one field ends and the other begins.

Then one fence post begins to lean. Nobody fixes it. A strand of wire breaks. Cattle begin crossing from one field into the other, and weeds grow around the remaining posts.

At first, everyone still remembers where the boundary belongs. But every season makes it harder to see. Eventually, a new generation inherits those farms. They did not watch the fence deteriorate. They simply grew up with cattle wandering between the fields and weeds covering the property line.

They look across the land and ask, 'Was there ever really a boundary here?'

The boundary did not move. Neglect made it difficult to see.

That is how moral and spiritual confusion often develops. It rarely begins with someone deliberately deciding that good and evil no longer matter. One conviction is ignored. One exception is made. One compromise becomes familiar. What once troubled the conscience becomes tolerated, and what is tolerated long enough begins to feel normal.

A boundary neglected long enough becomes a boundary forgotten.

That is the condition God confronted through Ezekiel in chapter twenty-two. God's people still had the Temple, priests, sacrifices, gatherings and the words of the Law. Outwardly, their religion was still operating. Inwardly, the fence lines had collapsed.

God said the priests had profaned holy things. They no longer put a difference between the holy and the profane, and they no longer showed the people the difference between the unclean and the clean. The people had not lost every religious activity. They had lost the ability to recognize what belonged to God and what did not.

Now bring that picture into our day. The same phone can bring us Scripture, worship and godly teaching, then moments later place violence, lust, bitterness, mockery and confusion before our eyes. Everything enters through the same screen. Everything competes for the same attention. If everything receives the same welcome, everything eventually begins to feel equally ordinary.

If we handle the clean and the unclean together and call them common, confusion has won, because the holy and the profane have become indistinguishable.

This message is not calling us to become religious policemen. We are not being sent to inspect everyone else's field while weeds overtake our own. The question is personal: What is shaping my mind? What is feeding my desires? What have I accepted simply because I have seen it repeatedly? What once troubled my spirit but now feels ordinary?

This is not a message about earning salvation through rules. It is about allowing the grace that saved us to teach us how to live. God does not merely want to place another fence around our behavior. Through the Holy Ghost, He wants to restore discernment within the heart.

When the lines grow gray, confusion begins to feel normal. But God has not left us without light.

Part One The Revelation in Ezekiel

Before we can understand what went wrong in Ezekiel's day, we must understand what God first placed into the hands of the priests. They were not asked to invent religious boundaries. They were entrusted with distinctions God had already established.

Leviticus chapter ten, verses ten and eleven, says:

"That ye may put difference between holy and unholy, and between unclean and clean; and that ye may teach the children of Israel all the statutes which the Lord hath spoken unto them by the hand of Moses."

Four words stand at the center of that command: holy, common, clean, and unclean. Let me name them again. Holy and common form the first distinction. Clean and unclean form the second distinction.

These words are related, but they are not interchangeable. Holy does not simply mean clean. Common does not automatically mean sinful. Clean does not necessarily mean consecrated. Unclean does not always mean morally guilty. So let us take the words one at a time.